but Mamata turned the tables on them by describing the ED action as an attack on Bengal's 'daughters and daughters-in-law'. "Throughout the filthy poll campaign, the prime minister mocked Mamata Banerjee, the home minister ridiculed her, the BJP underrated her credentials. Yet, she led the party to one of the most significant victories in the history of electoral politics," says Rajya Sabha MP Derek O'Brien. "That accomplished, her focus in the third term has swiftly shifted to industry, infrastructure and IT, all this while building the Trinamool—an organisation taking wing beyond her home state."

Mamata had two worthy competitors in 2021—Tamil Nadu chief minister M.K. Stalin and Assam's Himanta Biswa Sarma. Stalin, who assumed office after waiting in the wings for years, has displayed greater maturity in governance than his immediate predecessors. He has focused on administrative efficacy rather than political expediency in administration. While aspiring to make Tamil Nadu a $1 trillion economy by 2030, he also realises the pragmatic need to fulfil populist poll promises such as free bus travel for women and cheaper milk, and has also set up a mechanism for redressing public grievances. Stalin cuts a sober image than the temperamental Mamata and is very vocal about the need for cooperative federalism and greater autonomy for the states.

Another rising star is Sarma. The architect of the BJP's Northeast expansion led the party to its second consecutive assembly poll victory in Assam. That he replaced incumbent CM Sarbananda Sonowal underscores his importance in the BJP's plans for the Northeast. Sarma was an efficient minister in the Sonowal regime, though several decisions of his own government have been controversial. Among them is the anti-cattle smuggling law that restricts the sale of beef within 5 km radius of temples and *satras* (Vaishnav monasteries). The drive to reclaim government land from encroachers, most of them allegedly illegal Bangladeshi settlers, has sparked sporadic violence with critics dubbing it as a ploy to target Muslims.

Mamata has had her share of criticism too. She is considered unpredictable and a difficult coalition partner. Her detractors are already raising the bogey of her being flighty, citing past break-ups with the Congress and the BJP. To many, the confrontations with the Congress over her remarks on Rahul Gandhi, disagreements over the joint opposition strategy against the BJP for the 2024 general election, and the rampant poaching of Congress leaders are signs of a politician who cannot be trusted fully. Her declaration that the UPA (United Progressive Alliance) is as good as "dead" indicates she is unlikely to agree to any Congress-led anti-BJP front.

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–PAVAN K. VARMA
National V-P, Trinamool Congress

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–DEREK O'BRIEN
Rajya Sabha MP, Trinamool Congress

Nevertheless, the emphatic win in Bengal has positioned Mamata as perhaps the most credible challenger yet to PM Modi. She has the backing of veteran leaders like Sharad Pawar, Farooq Abdullah, Ghulam Nabi Azad and Subramanian Swamy. Former Rajya Sabha member Pavan K. Varma, who joined the TMC as national vice-president, says: "Mamata Banerjee has fire in her belly to take on the BJP. She has the indomitable resolve to build a better and saner India, one where different faiths are respected and human rights and constitutional values have sanctity."

The TMC's expansion bid has begun with BJP-ruled Goa and Tripura, where Congress leaders are being poached and the Mamata 'welfare model' advertised. To Goans, Mamata asked if the BJP's *achhe din* meant skyrocketing inflation while also talking about the Bengal government's basic monthly allowances for matriarchs of poor families. In Tripura, she has promised stipends for higher education of girls and free health insurance, like in Bengal.

While it's still early days, her moves have prompted incumbent governments to sit up and take notice. In August, Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman announced a Rs 1,300 crore package for Tripura's indigenous communities. As parties brace for crucial assembly polls early next year, expect Mamata to pitch herself higher. Any slip in the Congress's electoral fortunes will only posit her case as the challenger apparent to Modi in 2024.

Though Stalin and Sarma were outstanding in their electoral victories, it was the doughty Mamata who fought and won the battle of 2021 by stopping the mighty BJP in its tracks. For these reasons, she is the INDIA TODAY Politician of the Year. ■